

Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-
universality

Divine
control

Justice

Proportion- ality

Continuity

The result is that no one who is sent to heaven is very similar to anyone who is sent to hell. Does this solve the problem?

There are two residual issues.

One is that this appears to be a doctrine of the afterlife invented to solve this problem, rather than one actually taught by any religion.

The second is that it is not completely clear that it does solve the problem. Take two people who are very similar in their relevant properties, one sent to Purgatory and one sent to hell. Isn't the former vastly better off than the latter? If so, then (given Proportionality) God's decision to send them to different places must be unjust.



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox



evil & lives
not worth
living

the existence of a perfectly good God.

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traditional doctrine of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with

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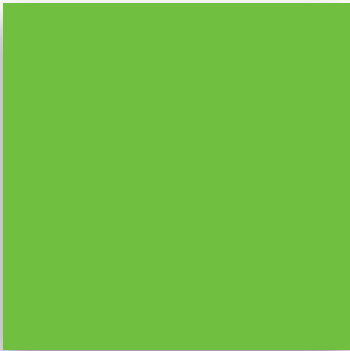
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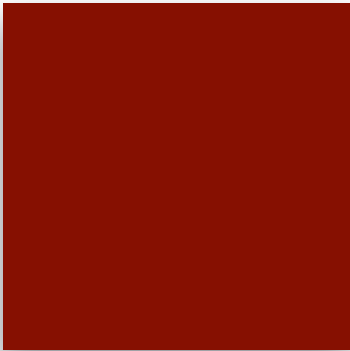












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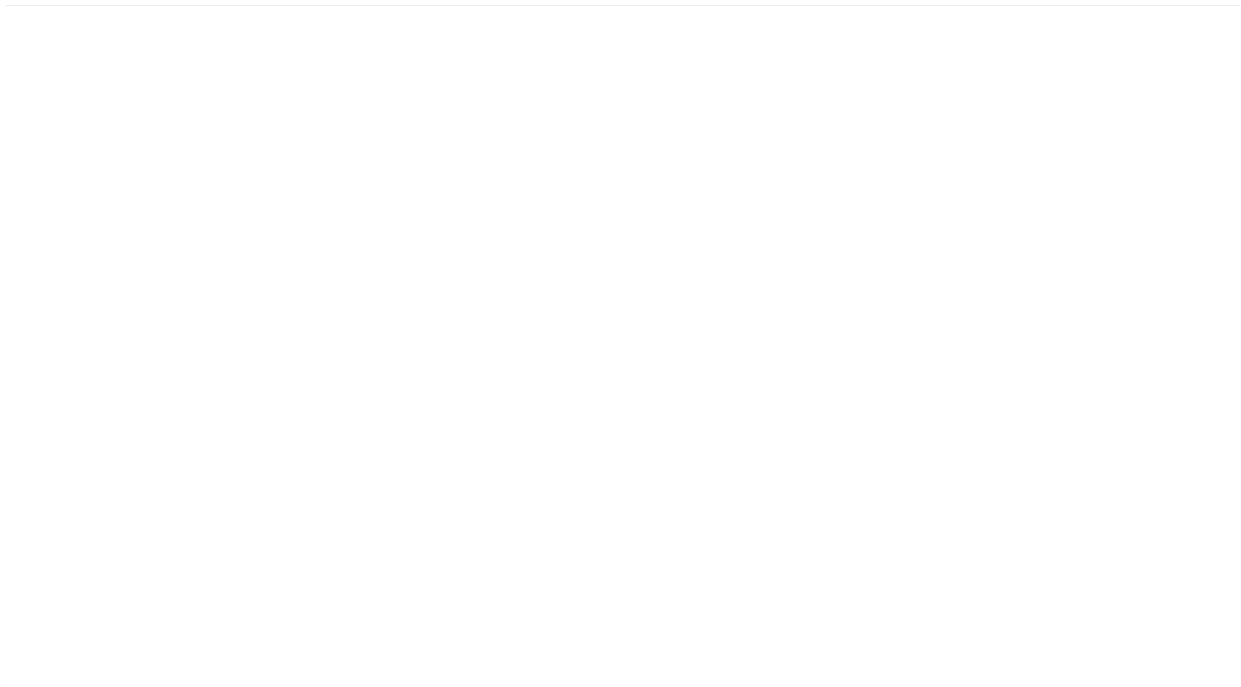
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The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:



all the nations, and he will separate them one from

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

eternis in die !!

into external punishment, but the rights into

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

many of the major monotheistic religions compatible with the existence of a

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

perfectly good Good?



but the rights are all in it.

they will go away into eternal punishment,

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

and the wild sheep are then from another

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

his glory, and all the angels with him . . .

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil











evil & lives
not worth
living

Badness

Dichotomy

Divine
control

Justice

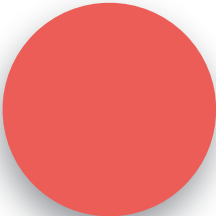


It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.



replies to the
paradox





the
paradox of
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